IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

Chronicle of a Death Foretold

Gabriel García Márquez · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs by chapter and across the novella
Dig deeper · Self-test

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How to use this guide

The novella has five unnumbered chapters. References take the form `3 (40%)`: chapter 3, about 40 per cent of the way through, rounded to the nearest 5 per cent. This works in any edition of Gregory Rabassa's translation.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs trace each concern through the five chapters, and Dig deeper sets out readings to test against the novella.

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 25 marks.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (5). B Analysis and evaluation (10), in two strands: B1 how meaning is shaped by language, technique, style and broader authorial choices (5); B2 the similarities and differences between the two works (5). C Focus and organisation (5). D Language (5).
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works, and criterion B2 assesses it directly.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through the characters to the choices the writer makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

The real case

The novella is based on the murder of Cayetano Gentile Chimento in Sucre, Colombia, in 1951. Gentile was a friend of García Márquez's family, and García Márquez waited many years before writing about it.

Source: LitCharts

Author and form

García Márquez worked for many years as a journalist; the novella was published in 1981, the year before he won the Nobel Prize. It is often read as a detective story and as part of the Latin American Boom.

Source: LitCharts

At a glance

Chapter	Setting	Events	Event titles
Chapter 1	The morning of the murder	E1–E5	The opening sentence; Waiting for the bishop; The kitchen; The twins wait; The returned bride
Chapter 2	Bayardo San Román and the wedding	E6–E8	Bayardo San Román arrives; The widower Xius's house; The wedding night and the name
Chapter 3	The twins' preparations	E9–E11	Honour and the surrender; Telling everyone; The mayor
Chapter 4	Autopsy, aftermath, Angela and Bayardo	E12–E13	The autopsy; Angela's letters
Chapter 5	The judge, the town, the killing	E14–E16	The judge's notes; The note under the door; The killing

Event bank

16 numbered events in order. Read one chapter for close revision, or E1 to E16 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Chapter 1

E1 The opening sentence 1 (0%)

The first sentence announces the murder and the hour Santiago Nasar got up 1 (0%); the narrator gathers memories twenty-seven years later 1 (0%).

Why it matters. The ending is given away at once: suspense moves from what happens to how it could have been allowed to happen.

Dig deeper. If we know the ending, what keeps us reading?

E2 Waiting for the bishop 1 (25%)

The town gathers to greet the bishop's boat; Santiago's mother predicts the bishop will not land 1 (25%).

Why it matters. The church passes by on the river while a death is prepared in the square.

E3 The kitchen 1 (25–30%)

Victoria Guzmán and her daughter Divina Flor serve Santiago coffee 1 (30%); Victoria had been seduced by his father 1 (30%).

Why it matters. Santiago's household contains its own history of sexual power, set beside the accusation against him.

E4 The twins wait 1 (55%)

The Vicario twins wait for Santiago in Clotilde Armenta's milk shop opposite his house 1 (55%).

Why it matters. The killers wait in public view.

E5 The returned bride 1 (90%)

The narrator's sister learns that Angela Vicario, married the day before, has been returned to her parents because she was not a virgin 1 (90%).

Why it matters. The motive is revealed only after the killing has been fixed as certain.

Chapter 2

E6 Bayardo San Román arrives 2 (0–5%)

Bayardo San Román, a rich outsider, arrives and decides to marry Angela 2 (0%); he wins her family with money, buying every raffle ticket 2 (20%).

Why it matters. Marriage is a transaction; Angela's mother arranges it over Angela's doubts.

E7 The widower Xius's house 2 (45%)

Bayardo buys the widower Xius's house for Angela, overriding the old man's reluctance 2 (45%).

Why it matters. Money buys even memories that are not for sale.

E8 The wedding night and the name 2 (55–100%)

Angela's friends tell her how to fake virginity 2 (55%); she refuses to deceive. Returned home and beaten, she names Santiago Nasar 2 (100%).

Why it matters. The name is given in a single sentence with no evidence.

Dig deeper. The narrator never confirms that Santiago was guilty. What does the novella gain by leaving it open?

Chapter 3

E9 Honour and the surrender 3 (0–5%)

The court accepts that the killing defended honour 3 (0%). The twins surrender to Father Amador: they killed openly but are innocent 3 (0%).

Why it matters. The law confirms the code that made the murder possible.

E10 Telling everyone 3 (10–15%)

The twins sharpen their knives at the meat market and tell everyone what they mean to do 3 (10%); their reputation as good people means no one believes them 3 (15%).

Why it matters. The twins seem to want to be stopped.

Dig deeper. Why do the twins announce the murder to everyone they meet?

E11 The mayor 3 (30%)

Colonel Lázaro Aponte takes the twins' knives 3 (30%) and considers the matter closed; they fetch others.

Why it matters. Authority acts once and then goes to play dominoes.

Chapter 4

E12 The autopsy 4 (0–10%)

Father Amador, in the doctor's absence, performs a brutal autopsy 4 (0%).

Why it matters. The body is violated a second time, by a priest.

E13 Angela's letters 4 (90–100%)

Angela writes to Bayardo for years 4 (90%); he returns with almost two thousand letters 4 (100%), all unopened 4 (100%).

Why it matters. The returned bride becomes the author of her own love story.

Dig deeper. Is Angela the novella's most independent character, or its most obsessed?

Chapter 5

E14 The judge's notes 5 (5–70%)

The investigating magistrate, reading Nietzsche, fills the brief with marginal notes 5 (10%), including that fatality makes us invisible 5 (70%).

Why it matters. The law turns to philosophy because it cannot explain how a town let it happen.

E15 The note under the door 5 (35%)

A warning note had been slipped under Santiago's door; no one saw it 5 (35%).

Why it matters. One of many chances that fail.

E16 The killing 5 (80–100%)

His mother, believing he is upstairs, slams and bars the front door 5 (85%), and Santiago is killed against it. He walks round to the back, holding his entrails 5 (100%), and falls in the kitchen 5 (100%).

Why it matters. The novella ends at the moment of death, not after it.

Characters

Santiago Nasar

Twenty-one, son of an Arab immigrant father, heir to a ranch.

- Dresses in white for the bishop 1 (20%).
- Accused by Angela 2 (100%).
- Dies in his kitchen 5 (100%).

Arc. The novella never establishes his guilt.

Angela Vicario

The bride returned on her wedding night.

- Names Santiago 2 (100%).
- Writes to Bayardo for years 4 (100%).

Arc. From exchanged bride to writer of her own story.

Pedro and Pablo Vicario

Angela's twin brothers, pig butchers.

- Announce the killing 3 (10%).
- Claim innocence 3 (0%).

Arc. Acquitted on grounds of honour.

Bayardo San Román

A wealthy outsider.

- Buys the raffle and the house 2 (20%).
- Returns years later with the letters unopened 4 (100%).

Arc. The man whose rejection begins the chain.

The narrator

A friend of Santiago's who returns to investigate twenty-seven years later 1 (0%).

- Gathers contradictory testimony.

Arc. An investigator who cannot reach a verdict.

Issues

Each issue is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Fate, chance and foreknowledge

The title and first sentence announce the death; the novella then shows a town in which almost everyone knew and no one stopped it.

Chapter 1	The day begins with the death foretold 1 (0%). Quotations: Q1, Q5
Chapter 2	The name is given as an already written sentence 2 (100%). Quotations: Q10
Chapter 3	The twins tell everyone 3 (10%). Quotations: –
Chapter 4	The town lives with the aftermath for years 4 (100%). Quotations: –
Chapter 5	The magistrate blames fatality 5 (70%); a warning lies unseen 5 (35%). Quotations: Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21

The whole arc. Fate in the novella is the sum of human failures to act.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Is Santiago's death fated, or chosen by everyone who did nothing?

Honour and the code of masculinity

The killing is demanded by a code of honour that the twins, the court and much of the town accept.

Chapter 1	Angela is returned for not being a virgin 1 (90%). Quotations: Q4, Q6
Chapter 2	Her family beats her until she names a man 2 (100%). Quotations: –
Chapter 3	The court accepts the defence of honour 3 (0%); the twins claim innocence 3 (0%). Quotations: Q11, Q12
Chapter 4	Women support the code: Prudencia Cotes knew and approved 3 (60%). Quotations: –
Chapter 5	The killing is performed in public, as the code requires 5 (100%). Quotations: Q14

The whole arc. Honour requires a death and does not require proof.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Do the twins want to kill Santiago, or do they want to be seen trying?

Collective responsibility

The question the narrator investigates is how a whole town allowed a death everyone knew about.

Chapter 1	The killers wait in public 1 (55%). Quotations: Q5
Chapter 2	The town celebrates the wedding. Quotations: –
Chapter 3	No one takes the twins seriously 3 (15%); the mayor takes their knives and stops there. Quotations: Q13
Chapter 4	The autopsy and aftermath show the town's lasting guilt. Quotations: –
Chapter 5	The magistrate finds no single cause 5 (70%). Quotations: Q18

The whole arc. Responsibility is spread so widely that no one holds it.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Who is most to blame for Santiago's death?

Women, virginity and marriage

Women's bodies carry family honour, and women are both its enforcers and its victims.

Chapter 1	Victoria Guzmán's history with Ibrahim Nasar 1 (30%). Quotations: Q4, Q6
Chapter 2	Angela is married off for money 2 (20%). Quotations: Q8, Q9
Chapter 3	Prudencia Cotes's mother tells the twins that honour does not wait 3 (60%); Prudencia approves 3 (60%). Quotations: –
Chapter 4	Angela writes to Bayardo for years 4 (100%). Quotations: Q16, Q17
Chapter 5	Women warn, bar doors and witness 5 (100%). Quotations: Q14

The whole arc. Angela begins as an object exchanged and ends as a writer.

Dig deeper

- Is Angela a victim or an agent?

Memory, truth and the chronicle

The narrator reconstructs the day from contradictory memories, like a journalist or an investigator.

Chapter 1	Witnesses disagree even about the weather 1 (25%). Quotations: Q2
Chapter 2	Angela never retracts the name. Quotations: –
Chapter 3	Testimonies multiply. Quotations: –
Chapter 4	The narrator visits Angela years later. Quotations: –
Chapter 5	The magistrate's brief is incomplete 5 (10%). Quotations: –

The whole arc. The more is known, the less is explained.

Dig deeper

- Can the truth about a collective act ever be reconstructed?

Issue and chapter grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that issue's arc.

Issue	Chapter 1	Chapter 2	Chapter 3	Chapter 4	Chapter 5
Fate, chance and foreknowledge	Q1, Q5	Q10			Q18, Q19, Q20, Q21
Honour and the code of masculinity	Q4, Q6		Q11, Q12		Q14
Collective responsibility	Q5		Q13		Q18
Women, virginity and marriage	Q4, Q6	Q8, Q9		Q16, Q17	Q14
Memory, truth and the chronicle	Q2				
Religion, ritual and sacrifice	Q3			Q15	
Class, wealth and outsiders		Q7, Q8			

García Márquez’s methods

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

Inverted suspense

The end is given in the first sentence 1 (0%); the novella builds suspense around how, not whether.

The chronicle and the journalist narrator

The narrator writes like a reporter, quoting witnesses and dates 1 (0%).

Non-linear structure

Each chapter returns to the morning of the murder from a different angle and ends with the death foreshadowed or achieved 5 (100%).

Detail and the grotesque

The autopsy 4 (0%) and Santiago’s last walk are described with flat precision.

Dig deeper

The surface overview is in the event bank and issue arcs. These sections go further: the real case behind the novella, the chronicle form, honour, fate and responsibility, and religion and sacrifice. Every claim about the novella is referenced; critical readings are offered for evaluation.

Foreknowledge and responsibility

On the surface. The death was fated.

It could be argued that the novella's real subject is not fate but collective inaction: the twins announce their plan 3 (10%), the mayor disarms them once, a warning note lies unseen 5 (35%), and the magistrate falls back on fatality 5 (70%).

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - How many people could have stopped the murder? Why did none of them?

Honour as performance

On the surface. The twins kill for honour.

The court accepts honour as a defence 3 (0%), and the narrator's mother says honour is love 5 (5%). One reading is that the twins want to be stopped, and kill because no one stops them: honour is something performed for the town.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is honour a private value or a public performance in the novella?

The chronicle form

On the surface. A detective story.

The narrator returns twenty-seven years later 1 (0%) and assembles testimony like a journalist, but never reaches a verdict on Santiago's guilt. It could be read as a detective story with the solution withheld, a form that critics have compared with Borges and Kafka.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why does the narrator never decide whether Santiago was guilty?

Religion and sacrifice

On the surface. A murder.

The bishop will not land 1 (25%), a priest performs the autopsy 4 (0%), and Santiago dies in a ritual manner in public. It could be argued that the novella presents the killing as a sacrifice that the community requires.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - What role does the church play in the death?

Quote bank

21 quotations in order of appearance.

Chapter 1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	1 (0%)	“ON THE DAY THEY WERE GOING TO KILL him” The first words: the death is known before anything else. Fate
Q2	1 (0%)	“twenty-seven years later” The narrator’s distance from the event. Memory
Q3	1 (25%)	“He won't even get off the boat” The bishop’s indifference, predicted. Religion
Q4	1 (30%)	“She'd been seduced by Ibrahim Nasar” A history of male power in Santiago’s own household. Women · Honour and the code of masculinity
Q5	1 (55%)	“waiting for Santiago Nasar in order to kill him” The killers wait in plain view. Fate · Collective responsibility
Q6	1 (90%)	“her husband had discovered that she wasn't a virgin” The motive, stated flatly. Women · Honour and the code of masculinity

Chapter 2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q7	2 (5%)	“Bayardo San Roman was not a man to be known at first sight” The stranger whose money buys a bride. Class
Q8	2 (20%)	“had bought all the tickets in the raffle” Courtship as purchase. Class · Women
Q9	2 (55%)	“they made me believe that they were experts in men's tricks” Women’s knowledge passed on as a deception. Women

Q10	2 (100%)	“whose sentence has always been written” The name is given as a sentence already passed. Fate

Chapter 3

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q11	3 (0%)	“homicide in legitimate defense of honor” The court ratifies the code. Honour and the code of masculinity
Q12	3 (0%)	“We killed him openly” Pride and innocence in the same breath. Honour and the code of masculinity
Q13	3 (15%)	“no one paid any attention to them” A town that does not listen. Collective responsibility

Chapter 4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q15	4 (0%)	“the unforgiving autopsy” The second violation of the body. Religion
Q16	4 (100%)	“almost two thousand letters” Angela’s years of writing. Women
Q17	4 (100%)	“they were all unopened” The letters were never read. Women

Chapter 5

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q14	5 (5%)	“Honor is love” The narrator’s mother’s view, repeated as common sense. Honour and the code of masculinity Women
Q18	5 (70%)	“Fatality makes us invisible” The magistrate’s attempt to explain. Fate Collective responsibility

Q19	5 (35%)	“He went in without seeing the paper on the floor” A warning missed. Fate
Q20	5 (100%)	“They've killed me, Wene child” Santiago’s last words, oddly polite. Fate
Q21	5 (100%)	“fell on his face in the kitchen” The last words of the novella. Fate

Self-test

6 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **At what time does Santiago get up?**
   Five-thirty in the morning / Four / Seven / Six
2. **Why was Angela returned to her parents?**
   He was bankrupt / Her husband discovered she was not a virgin / She refused him / She stole from him
3. **Where do the twins sharpen their knives?**
   At Clotilde's shop / At home / At the church / At the meat market
4. **Who performs the autopsy?**
   Dr Iguarán / Father Amador / The magistrate / The mayor
5. **How many letters does Angela write?**
   Almost two thousand / None / Six / Three hundred
6. **What does the magistrate write in the margin?**
   Fatality makes us invisible / God is dead / Honour is love / Justice is blind

Answers

1. Five-thirty in the morning 1 (0%)
2. Her husband discovered she was not a virgin 1 (90%)
3. At the meat market 3 (10%)
4. Father Amador 4 (0%)
5. Almost two thousand 4 (100%)
6. Fatality makes us invisible 5 (70%)

Sources

- Gabriel García Márquez, *Chronicle of a Death Foretold* (1981), translated by Gregory Rabassa.
- LitCharts on *Chronicle of a Death Foretold*; Bloom's Critical Views: Gabriel García Márquez.